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Advancing AI Adoption: Strengths and Gaps in the European Digital Innovation Hubs Network

Insights from the first generation of EDIHs

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EDIH | European Digital Innovation Hubs Network

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Abstract

This report investigates the strengths and gaps in the European Digital Innovation Hubs (EDIH) Network in its first stage, with regards to advancing AI adoption within Europe. As announced in the AI Continent Action Plan, the second generation of EDIHs will become AI experience centres and need to reinforce their AI-related services and capacities. From 16 extensive interviews conducted with a diverse sample of EDIHs and complemented with EDIH-reported data on their activities, the report offers an in-depth analysis of capabilities of the first generation of EDIHs, such as identifying and addressing customers' challenges, helping customers implement AI solutions, leveraging the AI ecosystem, and raising awareness and skills for AI. In this first phase, the EDIHs demonstrate strong capacity in understanding and addressing customer challenges related to AI adoption through substantial support like awareness sessions, training programs, and mentoring. EDIHs are supporting established AI applications more commonly than cutting-edge ones, which coincides with the limited AI readiness of their customers, as successfully adopting AI requires a foundational level of digital maturity, including a solid digital business strategy, skills, processes, and infrastructure. Primary sectors of AI adoption are manufacturing, health care, and energy. EDIHs are well-connected with digital providers, AI experts, and testing facilities, but they have fewer links with regulatory bodies affecting full AI implementation support. While EDIHs are active in raising AI awareness and enhancing skills, most show shortcomings in assessing social and environmental impacts and need improvements in providing regulation and ethics guidance. To address this challenge, the Apply AI Strategy will propose how to better prepare the second generation of the Network to serve as first line help desks for regulatory compliance.

Executive summary

This report investigates the capability of the first generation of the European Digital Innovation Hubs (EDIH) Network in advancing AI adoption across the private and public sectors in Europe. The EDIH Network comprises 151 EDIHs established since 2023 and funded under the Digital Europe Programme, and by September 2024, more than 80% of them have delivered AI services to their customers.

From 16 extensive interviews conducted with a diverse sample of EDIHs from various regions in Europe and complemented with EDIH-reported data on their activities, the report offers an in-depth analysis of the following capabilities of EDIHs: identifying and addressing customers' challenges, helping customers implement AI solutions, leveraging the AI ecosystem, and increasing awareness of AI opportunities and training the workforce.

EDIHs demonstrate capabilities in understanding and addressing customer challenges related to AI adoption. The main barriers that EDIH identified for their customers are the availability and quality of data for AI implementation, and the lack of awareness and education on AI. EDIHs provide substantial support through AI-tailored awareness sessions, training programs, and mentoring to improve data collection processes. In addition, some EDIHs have developed AI maturity assessment tools to gauge customer readiness and frame appropriate implementation roadmaps.

EDIHs display a higher proficiency in supporting the implementation of AI for established applications such as machine learning and data analytics than for cutting-edge ones like expert systems and robotics. The primary sectors experiencing AI adoption with EDIH support include manufacturing, health care, and energy. Most implementations rely on customers' and public datasets rather than private ones and, in this first stage, EDIHs are not acting as trusted data intermediaries, i.e. collecting private data, anonymising it and sharing it with other companies for AI model testing.

While EDIHs are well-connected to digital providers, AI experts, and testing and experimentation facilities, they have more limited links with regulatory frameworks and sandbox providers as well as standardisation bodies. In the second generation of the EDIH Network, EDIHs will need better links to regulatory basis to be able to act as the first line help desks for regulatory compliance. EDIHs support customers in access to finance, although funding is not specific to AI. EDIHs are sometimes aware of other AI initiatives in their local ecosystem but they were little knowledgeable of the AI Factories, although this sub-component of the EuroHPC Joint Undertaking initiative was not yet completed at the time of interviews. At the time, only a third of them could perceive the relevance of these AI Factories for their customers.

Finally, EDIHs display enthusiasm in raising awareness of AI opportunities and enhancing workforce skills. However, EDIHs need improvement on assessing the social and environmental impacts of AI and providing regulation and ethics guidance. Respondents expressed a strong interest in enhancing their regulatory compliance capacities and service offer and identify a need to implement systematic procedures to check compliance with the AI Act during implementation.

1 Introduction

While small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) and public sector organisations (PSOs) continue to face challenges in adopting digital solutions and introducing digital innovations, public sector interventions bear promises in easing these challenges. The European Commission has made the digital transformation of companies and the public sector one of its top priorities.[1]

Since 2023, the European Commission established a network of European Digital Innovation Hubs (EDIHs) to support the digital transformation of SMEs and PSOs. The 151 EDIHs are consortia of research and technology organisations, universities, and private sector companies (De Nigris, Kalpaka, & and Nepelski, 2023). They assess the digital maturity of their customers[2] and provide a range of services for free or at a low cost: networking and access to innovation ecosystems, training and skills development,[3] support to find investment, and testing technologies and solutions before investing in them. These services rely on technologies from the most established, such as logistics or internet services and applications, to the most frontier ones, such as artificial intelligence (AI) and decision support or internet of things.

By the end of 2024, more than 80% of EDIHs already delivered services involving artificial intelligence (Carpentier, D'Adda, Nepelski, & and Stake, 2025). Among companies approaching EDIHs, SMEs are less digitalised than larger firms. They exhibit also lower levels of adoption of AI and automation technologies (Carpentier, D'Adda, Nepelski, & and Stake, 2025).[4] In the digital transformation process of EDIH customers, the first step is to establish a business strategy that identifies the relevant digital innovations for the company needs, then collecting and managing data, recruiting, training and empowering employees, and the last step is to implement AI and automation (Carpentier, D'Adda, Nepelski, & and Stake, 2025).

These main trends rely on the data collected systematically from EDIHs. While they offer an interesting overview of the EDIH Network's AI-related activities, they remain superficial and do not identify, for instance, the branches or applications of AI involved, the regulatory skills of the EDIHs or the difficulties their customers face when adopting these technologies. To better understand the AI-related capabilities in the EDIH Network, we carried out 16 interviews with EDIH representatives. Considering the scope of EDIHs' activities, we adopt a broad definition of relevant capabilities that encompasses:

- identifying customers' challenges in AI adoption and finding appropriate strategies to overcome them,
- accompanying the implementation of AI solutions in clients' digital transformation,

[1] Its first priority, a new plan for Europe's sustainable prosperity and competitiveness, includes "boosting productivity with digital tech diffusion to strengthen EU's competitiveness and become a leader in AI innovation", and "turbo charging investment to accelerate green, digital and social transition" (European Commission: Directorate-General for Communication and Leyen, U. v. d., 2024).

[2] Using the Digital Maturity Assessment Tool (DMAT), developed by the European Commission. For more information about the tool, see Kalpaka, Rissola, De Nigris, & Nepelski (2023).

[3] Training and skills development represent 30% of all the services that EDIHs delivered until the end of 2024, and 39% of them are related to artificial intelligence (see Table 1).

[4] This finding relies on almost 9,000 digital maturity assessment of EDIHs customers performed prior to delivering services.

— leveraging the AI ecosystem to support their customers' AI-related needs, and

— increasing AI awareness and skills.

In the second section, we define more in details the relevant capabilities related to AI that we aim at measuring, justify our choice of a qualitative approach, and describe interview participants compared to the rest of the EDIH Network. In the third section, we present the findings, grouped into the four main capabilities. In the last section, we conclude and provide a few policy recommendations.

2 Methodology and sample

In this section, we define the assessed capabilities related to AI, describe the empirical approach to identify them, and characterise the sample of EDIHs that participated in the interviews compared to the rest of the EDIH Network.

2.1 Definition of EDIHs' AI capabilities

EDIHs' mission is to support the digitalisation of SMEs and public sector, with a focus on AI technologies. In a general way, they execute this mission through four broad categories of activities:

- raising awareness of digital solutions and their benefits for organisations,
- developing and testing solutions before organisations invest into them,
- training and educating organisations and their employees on digital topics, and
- supporting organisations in accessing financing for their digital transformation.

Considering the wide scope of these activities, we define a set of capabilities and finer-grained functions in relation with AI, as reported in Table 1.[5]

Table 1. Definition of AI-relevant capabilities of EDIHs

Capability	Relevant function(s)
Identifying customers' challenges in adopting AI and establishing a strategy to solve them, including assessing the feasibility and relevance of AI solutions for customers.	• AI adoption road mapping • Test before invest & solution screening
Accompanying the implementation of AI solutions in clients' digital transformation, by offering support in different branches and applications of AI in different sectors and sourcing and managing data for AI implementation.	• Solution deployment support
Leveraging the AI ecosystem to serve their customers' needs in AI, through matchmaking, facilitating access to finance for AI, and positioning themselves in the AI landscape.	• Support to find investment for AI • Innovation ecosystem & networking
Increasing awareness around AI opportunities and training the workforce on AI skills, while • Accounting for the environmental and social impacts of AI in awareness raising, training and implementation activities, • Increasing customers' understanding of legislation and regulations related to AI and supporting regulatory compliance during implementation, and • Supporting other EDIHs in the EDIH Network, e.g. through clients' takeover or training them in AI topics and tools.	• Test before invest & solution screening • Talent development • Regulation and ethics guidance • Capacity building for EDIHs

Source: JRC elaboration.

[5] The list of fine-grained functions is available in questions 18 and 19 in Appendix Table 3.

2.2 Methodology

Considering the extent and nature of the AI capabilities that we aim to assess, as well as the particular setup in which EDIHs operate, this subsection describes the data sources available and justifies the selection of a qualitative approach.

2.2.1 Data from the EDIH platform

The first and directly available source of data, as mentioned in the introduction, are the ones that EDIH report in the EDIH platform[6] and describing their activities and associated customers in details. This data was useful to produce previous reports on EDIHs characteristics, activities and customers (De Nigris, Kalpaka, & and Nepelski 2023; Carpentier, D'Adda, Nepelski, & and Stake, 2025). Despite the exhaustivity of these data, they remain superficial regarding the specific branches or applications of AI involved in the service delivery,[7] and do not characterise, for instance, the source of data used in AI implementation, EDIHs' AI regulatory expertise or their ability to act as trusted data intermediaries.[8]

2.2.2 Data on scientific and technological outputs of organisations

Another, potentially more objective, source of information on EDIHs' AI capabilities are the scientific publications and patent records of their participating organisations. Not only would it be limited to scientific and technical capabilities, overlooking entirely networking and other soft skills relevant for EDIHs, but it would not be suitable to the EDIHs' setup, and other innovation intermediaries alike, for the following reason.

Three main groups of actors are involved in innovation intermediaries' activities: organisations that generate the AI knowledge and innovations ("AI developers"), organisations that form the EDIHs (AI innovation intermediaries, or "AI intermediaries" for short), and organisations that receive support from the innovation intermediaries to adopt AI ("AI users"). These groups are not entirely separate, for example some AI developers may belong to AI intermediaries, although this is not a requirement if AI intermediaries have sufficient links to AI developers. In addition, the presence of AI developers within the AI intermediary may increase the recognition of opportunities to commercialise an AI solution and facilitate its provision. However, the presence of developers within the intermediary is independent of the capability of the AI intermediary in its broader functions, such as assessing the full digital needs of the potential user and whether the AI solutions available "in-house" are indeed the relevant solution for their needs or providing legal support if the solution involves the development of a tailored AI solution. In this context, following paper trails of scientific publications and patent applications of organisations forming an AI intermediary is not appropriate, since it would only be informative of AI capabilities of the narrow subset of AI developers within the AI intermediary.

[6] The EDIH platform is managed by the Digital Transformation Accelerator (DTA). Digital Transformation Accelerator for the network of European Digital Innovation Hubs | European Digital Innovation Hubs Network

[7] EDIHs can indicate if an activity is related to AI using a tag ("Artificial intelligence and decision support"), and there is a free text field for EDIHs to describe the content of the service in more details that is rarely filled in, but there is not a normalised field in which EDIHs can report the particular technology or content that the service relies on.

[8] Trusted data intermediaries are entities that are expected to provide a trusted and secure environment in which companies or individuals can share data for testing and developing of AI innovations.

2.2.3 A qualitative approach

Considering the limitations of using a large-scale quantitative approach, we decided to select a qualitative one, interviews, that would allow to explore the various capabilities that we are interested in, while facilitating a possible later survey to extend to the rest of the EDIH Network. The first 7 interviews belonged to a pilot group, on which the applicability and relevance of the questions were tested and the EDIHs were also invited to provide feedback on potentially relevant topics that we initially overlooked.

2.3 Sample of EDIHs

2.3.1 Sampling strategy

As the aim of the interviews is to determine the AI capabilities in the EDIH Network, we deliberately focused our attention on the EDIHs that were most likely to be involved in providing AI services, either as their main technology or as one of a few main technologies.

We aimed at covering at least 10% of the total population of EDIHs, which would be 15 out of the 151 EDIHs in the EDIH Network.[9] Policy officers at DG CNECT, who are in regular contact with the hubs, provided an initial list of 13 hubs that were among the most likely to be delivering AI services. They also included some EDIHs that are less focused on AI, to ensure some heterogeneity and verify the ability of the interview script to adapt to such cases.

We contacted the EDIH coordinators and their AI experts (if available) by email, explaining the aim of the interview, the expected format, content and outcome for DG CNECT and for themselves. To ensure the relevance and accuracy of information collected during the interview, we requested that the representatives most closely involved in the delivery of AI services participate in the interview.

10 EDIHs responded positively and participated in the interview. As we had not yet reached the target of 10% of the EDIH Network, we repeated the process and collected a second list of 10 more EDIHs. Six of them took part in the interview. This represents an overall response rate of 70%.

We conducted a total of 16 semi-structured interviews with EDIHs representatives in September and October 2024.[10] The list of questions asked during interview is reported in Annex Table 2. After the first pilot round of 7 interviews, we identified an opportunity to improve the data collection for a few specific questions related to the sectors, AI applications and technologies, and functions performed. We introduced a short survey accordingly, reported in Annex Table 4, that we sent to respondents ahead of the interview so the responses could be revised together during the interview rather than collected entirely at that time. This modification in the protocol substantially improved the completeness and accuracy of answers to these questions.

The interviews took place online and lasted on average one hour and 10 minutes, ranging from 50 minutes to one hour and 45 minutes. To maximise the extent and accuracy of information collected,

[9] At the time of the interviews, there were 151 EDIHs funded under the Digital Europe Programme. The other 74 Seals of Excellence have no reporting obligations since they are not funded by the European Commission and were therefore not considered in the analysis.

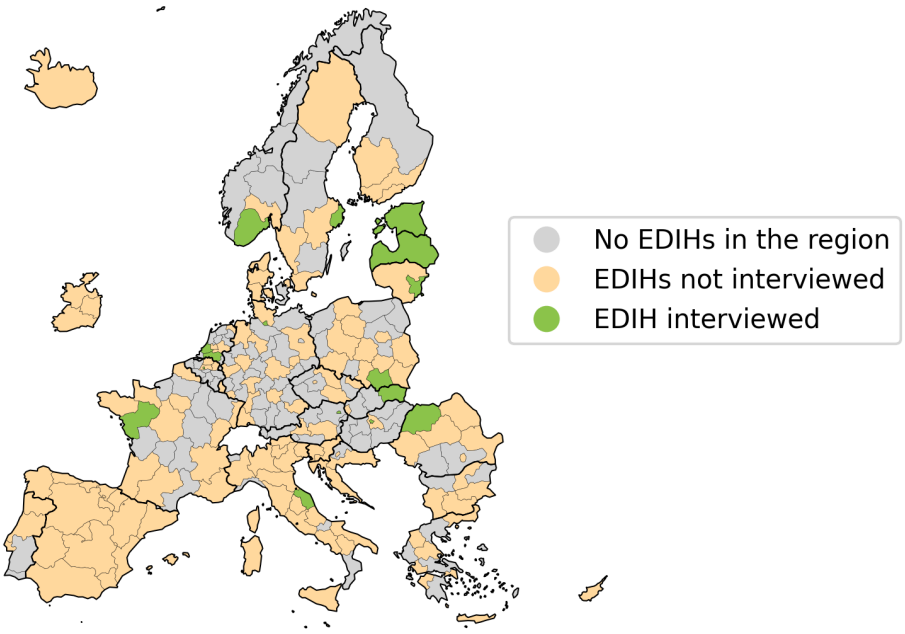
[10] The interview participants are AI5production, AIRE, DATA EDIH, DIGITALZH, DIVA, EDCASS, EDIH4IAE.LT, EDIH4MARCHE, EDIH4UrbanSAVE, EDIHLV, EDIH-SNL, H4i, HDS, OCEANOPOLIS, SustAIn.brussels, and TDIH.

we video recorded most of the interviews.[11] We also have the transcript of interviews from Microsoft Teams' embedded transcription service.

2.3.2 Interviewees characteristics

The map in Figure 1 shows in green the 16 regions of the 15 countries with EDIHs that participated in the interviews (there are two EDIHs in two regions of the Netherlands that were interviewed). Other regions with EDIHs that were not invited or declined to participate are in orange. The grey regions are those where there is no EDIH coordinator (although there may be EDIH participants). EDIHs interviewed were well distributed across the EDIH Network, with a slightly higher concentration in the North-Eastern countries.

Figure 1. Geographical location of interviewed and non-interviewed EDIHs



Note: EDIHs are located in the NUTS2 region of the coordinator. Four interviewed EDIHs located in Belgium, Hungary, Austria and Germany are difficult to distinguish on the map.

Source: JRC elaboration.

We further explore interviewees profile compared to the rest of the EDIH Network leveraging the data on services delivered as reported in the EDIH platform. The accuracy of this data was verified with EDIHs at the beginning of the interviews. In a few cases, these numbers were understating their service delivery either because they did not update the latest activities or a technical issue arose. Table 2 reports the average number and percentage of AI services per hub for interviewees and the rest of the EDIH Network separately, at the time of interviews. We identify the following noteworthy differences between the two groups:

[11] In two cases, the analysis relies on the interviewer's handwritten notes. In one case, the interview was relocated on a different platform due to authorisation issues and we could not record it, and in the other case the recording failed.

— First, interviewees are among the most active hubs in the EDIH Network:[12] they delivered 316 AI services per hub on average, compared to 41 in the rest of the EDIH Network.

— Second, the interviewees are specialised on AI to a greater extent than the rest of the EDIH Network: on average, 47% of their services involved AI technologies compared to 28% in the rest of the EDIH Network.

Third, the type of AI services delivered differs across the two groups, with interviewees being relatively more AI-focused in their "networking and access to innovation ecosystems" and "support to find investment" services, while the rest of the EDIH Network is more AI-focused in their "test before invest" and "training and skills development" services.

Table 2. Average number and share of AI services among interviewees and in the rest of the EDIH Network

	Interviewees		**Rest of the EDIH Network**	
Type of service	Average number of AI services	Average % of AI services	Average number of AI services	Average % of AI services
Networking	199	64%	20	23%
Funding	23	47%	11	21%
Test before invest	102	40%	19	34%
Skills	132	44%	24	30%
Total	316	47%	41	28%

Notes: There are 16 EDIHs in the group of interviewees, 13 of which delivered at least one AI-related service, and 107 reporting EDIHs in the group of the rest of the EDIH Network, of which 74 reported at least one AI-related service. In each sub-group, not all EDIHs have delivered AI services in each of the four types of services, so we report the average number of AI services rather than the raw count and the average percentage of AI services to account for these different group sizes.

Source: JRC elaboration.

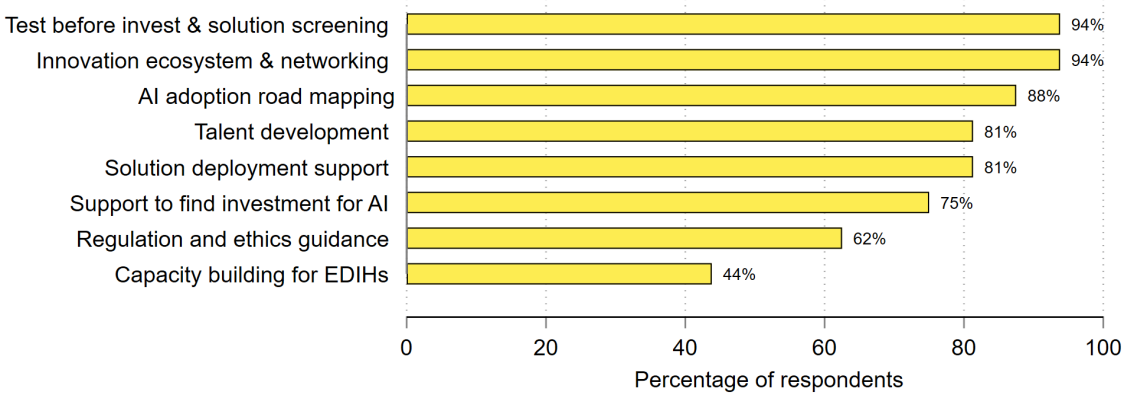
[12] This is true both for services relying on AI and all services overall.

3 AI capabilities and resources in the EDIH Network

In this section, we present the findings from the interviews, following the four categories of AI capabilities as defined in subsection 2.1: Identifying and addressing customers' challenges, helping customers implement AI solutions, leveraging the AI ecosystem, and increasing awareness of AI opportunities and training the workforce.

These capabilities were closely related to a set of 8 AI-related functions. To get an overview of the functions offered in the EDIH Network, Figure 2 shows the most to least common functions provided by respondents. EDIHs widely offer test before invest and solution screening (94%) as well as innovation ecosystem and networking services (94%). Talent development, which covers training and mentoring, is offered by 81% of respondents. The remaining respondents do not offer it because it is already widely available in their ecosystem at a low cost. 81% also offer AI solution deployment support, in which they accompany their customers in deploying an AI solution in their business operations. Relatively fewer offer support to find investment for AI, although many mentioned that they provide the service in a broader way without the funding being specific to an AI technology. Significantly fewer provide regulation and ethics guidance (62%) or capacity building for EDIHs, i.e. training other EDIHs in the Network (44%).

Figure 2. Percentage of respondents supporting their clients in 8 AI-related functions



Note: This figure displays the percentage of EDIHs which responded "yes" to providing the different AI-related functions. It corresponds to question 18 in Annex Table 3.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

Broadly speaking, the AI expertise available within the EDIH respondents mostly lies in the universities and research centres, while 25% of respondents have a partner with AI expertise from the private sector.

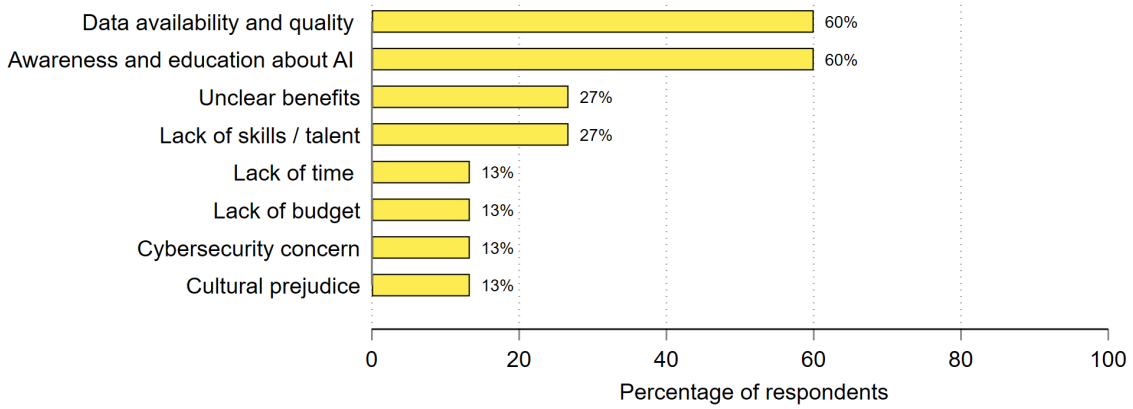
3.1 Identifying and addressing customers' challenges

The first capability that we assess is to identify customers' challenges in adopting AI and establishing a strategy to solve them, including by using or developing a dedicated AI maturity assessment tool.

3.1.1 Barrier to AI uptake among European SMEs and the public sector

Respondents indicate several barriers that their customers are facing in adopting AI. Figure 3 reports the different barriers mentioned by respondent by order of frequency.

Figure 3. Percentage of respondents citing common barriers their clients face when adopting AI



Note: This figure displays the percentage of EDIHs that mentioned the referenced category as a barrier to AI uptake among their customers. Each respondent could mention one or multiple barriers. It corresponds to question 12 in Annex Table 3.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

A first set of barriers relates to resource constraints:

- 60% of respondents indicate a barrier to AI implementation the lack of **availability and quality of data** that their clients are collecting, if any, to use as an input in implementing AI solutions.
- 27% of respondents further mention the **lack of skills or talent** in the organisation or its local talent pool. Some companies may have standard developers, but they cannot develop advanced AI solutions, so they need EDIH support for that. Other companies indicate that the local talent pool sometimes prefers to work for multinationals or leaves the country for better opportunities in Northern and Eastern European countries, leaving the local companies with an under skilled workforce.
- 13% of respondents mention the **lack of time**. Adopting AI is a lengthy, generally multi-step, process. Companies often don't have time to enter it. Taken in combination with other barriers (lack of good quality data, lack of skills, unclear benefits), it discourages AI adoption among EDIH clients.
- Similarly, 13% of respondent point to the **lack of financial resources** to invest in AI solutions or dedicate human resources to the adoption of AI, especially for SMEs.

Another important set of barriers relates to a limited AI literacy:

- The **lack of AI literacy** itself, i.e. awareness and education about artificial intelligence, is also mentioned by 60% of respondents. Many customers do not understand, or at a very superficial level, what AI is, what it can and cannot do, how it can be implemented in the organisation processes or even how to get started.

> *"Sometimes there is a huge confusion between deep learning, learning in general, and artificial intelligence in general, which includes for example, knowledge representation and reasoning. And we need to explain that."* TDIH, Romania

> *"[The main barrier is] unawareness of how AI is linked to business processes. [...] Let's make an example. We have a production company. It has its client research management system. It*

> *has its production management system, quality control, logistics and so on. So [we] need to go vertically in the business process and understand how to use AI. It's where are the bottlenecks, what doesn't work. And if we could make it work with AI and where is the reduction? Where is the increase in productivity and that is a bottleneck. We understand the technologies, but we don't understand how the technologies could work in terms of our business processes."* AIRE, Estonia

— The **unclear benefits of AI adoption** for customers are mentioned by 27% of respondents. Customers and EDIHs find it difficult to estimate the expected return on investment for AI adoption, especially for technologies or sectors where there exists too few use cases or success stories to build upon.

To a lesser extent, 13% of respondents mention the other following barriers:

— **Fear of cybersecurity threats** AI technologies may pose. Clients are concerned about the AI system learning from their activity and how their data gets out of their control. Public sector clients are particularly concerned about sharing citizen's data with AI solution providers in the market.

— **Intergenerational prejudice** against AI. Although the recent hype around ChatGPT and generative AI strongly reduced this prejudice, a respondent refers to a particular age group that remains resistant to change:

> *"If we get a little bigger [company] [...], we have a specific age rate of management persons that are really afraid of AI. So, we can build a prototype, but if it comes to: how can we bring that into the company? Do you want to use that? Then they [refuse and] bring up a lot of arguments that are not really rational."* EDIH4UrbanSAVE, Germany

All these barriers are quite consistent with those identified in other investigations. In an earlier and independent task, the JRC established a focus group on AI[13] and surveyed 98 companies on their use, barriers and impact of adopting AI. To the question of what constitutes a barrier to AI adoption, the three main answers were access to data, on which 94% of respondents (strongly) agree, access to finance (88%), and access to relevant skills (82%). Even though the point of view is different between the two exercises, with EDIHs' perception in the 16 interviews compared to the SMEs themselves in the focus group survey, the main barrier identified is consistent between the two studies, i.e. access and quality of data to implement AI solutions. Additionally, the access to relevant skills was also mentioned by a 27% of interview respondents, relatively less frequently than among SMEs from the focus group, while access to finance was seldom mentioned by EDIHs.

[13] in collaboration with the Digital SME Alliance: https://www.digitalsme.eu/european-focus-group-on-artificial-intelligence/

3.1.2 Current approaches to overcome barriers to AI uptake

During the interviews, EDIHs sometimes mentioned ways in which they address some of the barriers that their clients face in adopting AI, from creating or improving the data collection process to providing knowledge on the technologies, convincing and reassuring clients with rational arguments, training their staff and convincing higher management with AI prototypes.

3.1.2.1 Resource constraints

When data is not available in the clients' organisation or the quality is not sufficient to implement an AI solution, EDIHs would take a step back:

- Either help the client review if and how it collects its data and proceed to support them in implementing a proper data collection process. In some cases, EDIHs have the robots gathering data directly to train and calibrate their underlying AI models.
- Or connect the client with a service provider who would support the company in starting or improving their data collection process.

Any of these strategies delays the AI implementation, of course, but it enables it later.

To address the lack of skills, EDIHs offer trainings on AI tools,[14] and would help companies perform the necessary research and development to tailor an AI solution to the customers' need beyond what standard developers can do.

EDIHs also provide support to find investment when the required AI solution is too expensive for the client.

3.1.2.2 Limited AI literacy

Respondents are very active on raising awareness and increase the level of understanding of AI and its practical functioning. They organise trainings, seminars, webinars, professional development days to explain how AI works in practical ways, and what it can do:

> *"[We explain] how AI works in practice in the specific process of companies like AI in marketing, AI in sales, AI in production, very business-oriented functions."* EDIHLV, Latvia

> *"We need to be there and help them [the clients] sort of decrypt the AI and how to get started."* OCEANOPOLIS, Norway

EDIHs further help convincing their customers to adopt AI solutions by computing the return on investment early in the process. However, it can be difficult depending on the sector under consideration. The health sector was mentioned as easier compared to any other. While more and more success stories are being published, respondents are hopeful that these can help them in convincing their customers and allow customers to identify with the cases described in the stories so that EDIHs can estimate more precisely a potential return on investment.

[14] Respondents did not specify extensively the trainings offered. This topic will be thematic focus of a forthcoming report on activities in the EDIH Network, which will emphasise the role and activities of EDIHs in improving AI skills among European firms and public sector organisations.

"We are reading the [industry] reports. We are reading about these big multinational corporations that come out there. We read about jobs being replaced at sort of aggregate numbers, but what does it mean for my organisation? Are we speaking about jobs, or should we be speaking about tasks and processes? Our EDIH must help SMEs to get a grip on that one, making people understand, and where to start and do the right things to prepare the ground for AI." OCEANOPOLIS, Norway

"We did tailor the service called "AI suitability analysis". [We] help the company vertically in their business processes to understand where the reduction [in cost/bottleneck] comes if we use that technology and there's no sense of implementing an AI-enabled robot if, for example, there is no bottleneck or there is not enough clients or not enough production volumes, then it's cheaper that the human continues to do the work." AIRE, Estonia

3.1.2.3 Other barriers

To address cybersecurity concerns, EDIHs discuss the topic in workshops. When facing intergenerational prejudice and fear of AI, EDIH4UrbanSave mentions that they developed a service that is called "AI for leaders", in which they develop a prototype, just to show their clients how AI works and reassure them in that "it's not a robot that is taking over the world leadership".

Beyond all the previously mentioned client-oriented solutions, a few EDIHs also collaborate among themselves, sharing knowledge and experiences, such as use cases, facilitating access to AI infrastructures or addressing the needs of clients from other EDIHs with whom they established a partnership to further remove barriers to AI adoption.

3.1.3 A tool dedicated to assessing the AI maturity of customers

Although Figure 2 previously showed that 88% of respondent offer AI adoption road mapping services, only 19% of them have developed and are using a dedicated tool, in the form of a survey, to delve specifically in the challenges proper to AI adoption and identify the relevant AI solutions to address them. All other respondents are using the more generic Digital Maturity Assessment Tool (DMAT) provided by the European Commission (Kalpaka, Rissola, De Nigris, & Nepelski, 2023). 38% of them have considered developing or acquiring an additional AI-dedicated tool, but most of them consider it unnecessary because the DMAT already includes a section dedicated to the AI maturity of customers.

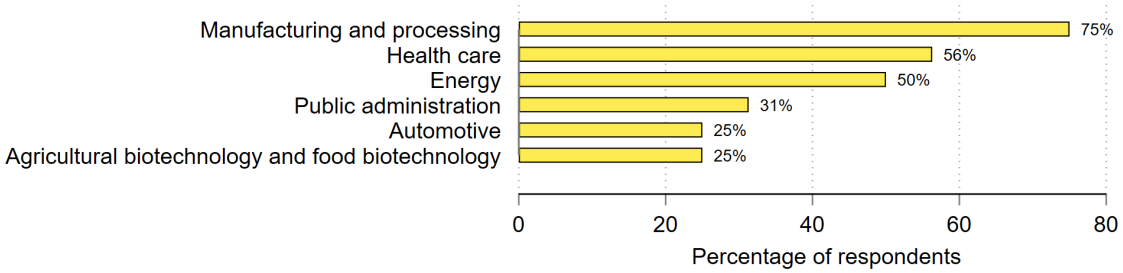
3.2 Helping customers implement AI solutions

The second capability that we assess is accompanying the implementation of AI solutions in clients' digital transformation, by offering support in different branches and applications of AI, in different sectors, and sourcing and managing data for AI implementation.

3.2.1 Sectors addressed

Consistent with the sample selection, 81% of respondents indicate that AI is either the main technology (50%) or one of the main technologies (31%) in their service delivery. Figure 4 shows that most respondents deliver AI services in manufacturing and processing (75%), health care (56%) and energy (50%). About a quarter of EDIHs also deliver AI services in public administration, agricultural biotechnology and food biotechnology and automotive. The other sectors (not displayed in Figure 4) are less common and gather fewer than 20% of respondents.

Figure 4. Top 6 sectors in which respondents have delivered AI services



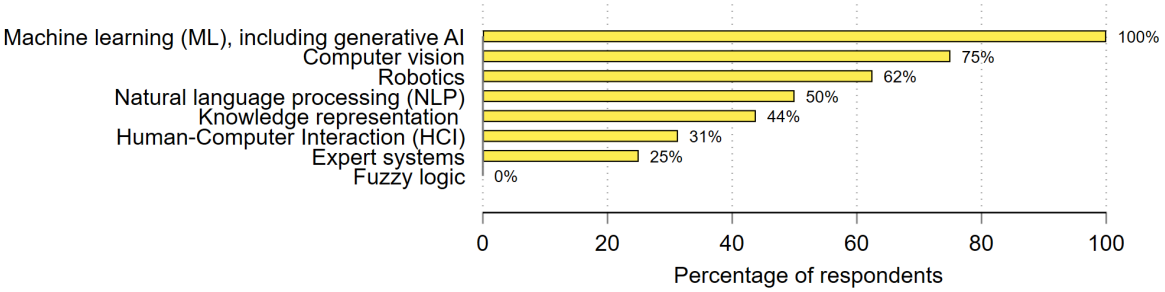
Note: This figure displays the 6 most frequent sectors in which respondents deliver AI services, corresponding to question 3 in Annex Table 3. There are 39 sectors in total, using the EDIH nomenclature. For 9 respondents, they checked the boxes in the pre-interview survey, 3 others filled it after the interview, and for the others their reply is inferred from the content of the remaining of the interview.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

3.2.2 Branches and applications of AI

Figure 5 indicates the share of respondents that have delivered services in eight branches of AI. All respondents have delivered services involving machine learning, which includes generative AI. Other common branches across the EDIH Network are computer vision, robotics, and natural language processing (50 to 75% of EDIHs). Expert systems and human-computer interaction are less common (25 and 31% of respondents respectively) and none of the respondents have delivered services involving fuzzy logic.

Figure 5. Percentage of respondents that used different branches of AI technologies in services delivered

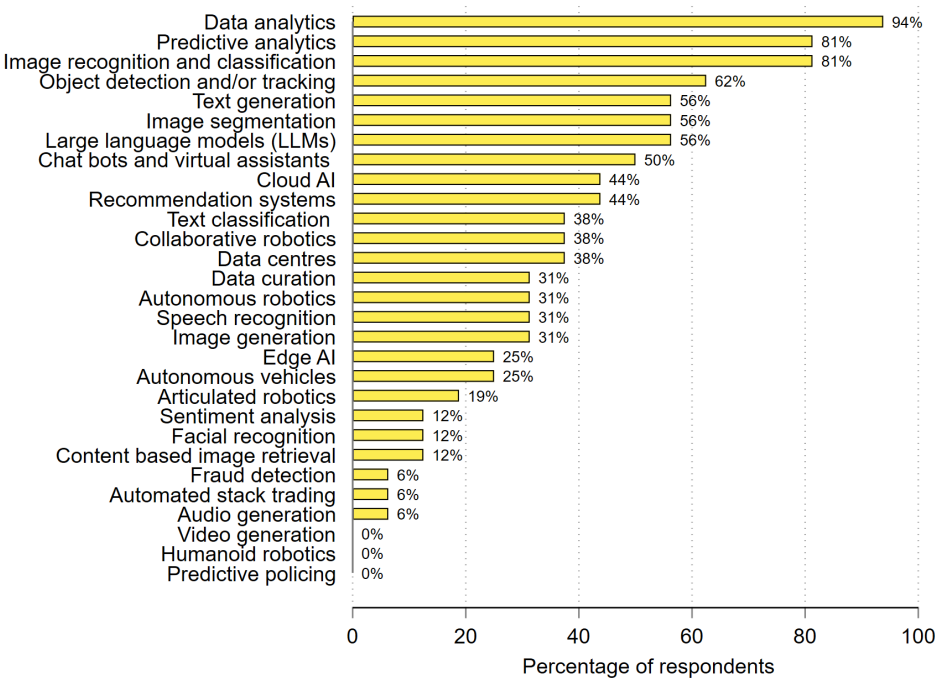


Note: This figure displays all the branches of AI in which respondents deliver AI services, corresponding to question 4 in Annex Table 3. For 9 respondents, they checked the boxes in the pre-interview survey, 3 others filled it after the interview, and for the others their reply is inferred from the content of the remaining of the interview.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

Taking a closer look at the specific AI applications that respondents provided, Figure 6 indicates that more than 80% of EDIHs are proficient in established applications such as data analytics, predictive analytics and image recognition and classification. Other common applications include text generation, LLMs and chat bots and virtual assistants (50 to 62% of respondents). EDIHs are less frequently reporting sentiment analysis (12%), audio generation (6%) or video generation (0%) as part of their AI service delivery.

Figure 6. Percentage of respondents currently using different AI applications to support clients' AI adoption



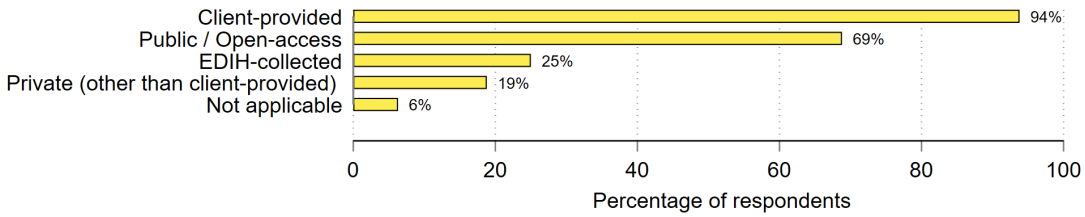
Note: This figure displays all AI-related applications involved in the service delivery of respondents, corresponding to question 5 in Annex Table 3. For 9 respondents, they checked the boxes in the pre-interview survey, 3 others filled it after the interview, and the others were asked to freely answer the question.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

3.2.3 Data sources and management

Figure 7 indicates the primary source of data that respondents used in AI applications with their clients. Setting aside one respondent that is not developing nor implementing AI applications with customers and therefore to whom the question was not applicable, all respondents indicated that they primarily work with the data provided by the client, although this often involved an additional preliminary step of ensuring a proper data collection on clients' side prior to the AI application development and/or implementation. 69% of respondents combine client-provided data with public or open-access datasets. It is less common to use EDIH partners' datasets (25% of respondents) or private datasets beyond the one provided by the client (19%).

Figure 7. Percentage of respondents using different sources of data in AI applications with their clients

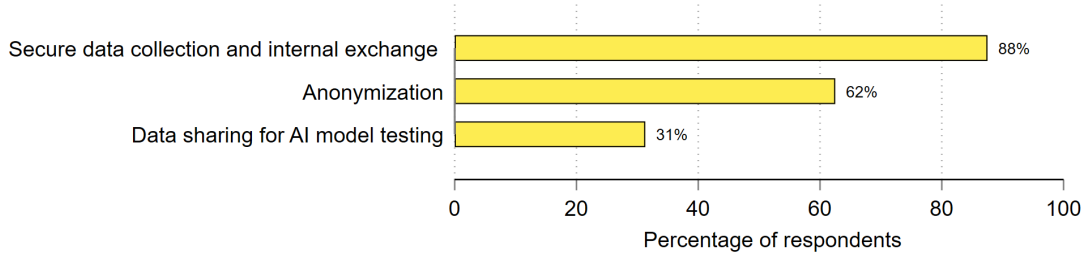


Note: This figure displays the different sources of data used by EDIHs in developing or implementing AI applications with their customers. It corresponds to the open-ended question 6 in Annex Table 3.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

Despite working mainly with client-provided datasets, some EDIH respondents did not see themselves as playing a leading role as trusted data intermediaries. Such a role implies collecting customers' data, anonymising it, and making it available to other companies for AI model testing. Figure 8 shows most respondents indicate proficiency in collecting and anonymising the data, and less so to share it for AI model testing. Respondents generally referred to a reticence from private sector customers to share any data and constraining EDIHs' actions through data sharing agreements.

Figure 8. Percentage of respondents with some ability to perform different functions of a trusted data intermediary



Note: This figure displays the percentage of respondents that indicated some ability and experience in performing the corresponding task. It corresponds to the open-ended question 7 in Annex Table 3.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

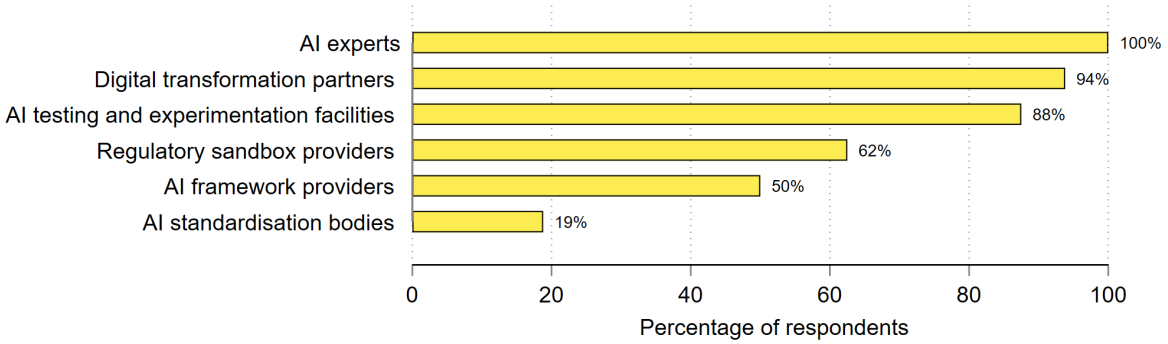
3.3 Leveraging the AI ecosystem

The third capability that we assess is to leverage the AI ecosystem to serve customers' needs in AI, through matchmaking, facilitating access to financing for AI and positioning themselves in the AI landscape.

3.3.1 Extent of EDIHs' network to support customers' needs

While most respondents are well-connected to AI experts, digital transformation partners and AI testing and experimenting facilities in their ecosystem, fewer of them (62%) are connected to regulatory sandbox providers, 50% to AI framework providers and only 19% to AI standardisation bodies (Figure 9). A few respondents did not know what regulatory sandboxes, AI frameworks and/or AI standardisation bodies are.

Figure 9. Percentage of respondents who know different types of actors in their ecosystem



Note: This figure displays the percentage of EDIHs which responded "yes" to knowing, in their ecosystem, an organisation providing the different categories of AI-related services. It corresponds to question 14 in Annex Table 3.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

3.3.2 Facilitating access to AI funding

In Figure 2, we noted that 75% of respondents indicate that they provide support to find investment for AI. However, during the interviews, many respondents clarified that this is rather a generic service since there are no funding streams dedicated specifically to AI.

3.3.3 Awareness of complementary or competing AI initiatives and strategic positioning

We asked interviewees if they were aware of other AI initiatives in their local ecosystem.[15] The specific scope was undefined, so respondents considered either their region (in bigger countries) or their country (for smaller ones). Two-third of respondents could identify AI initiatives around them, in Estonia, Hungary, Latvia, the Netherlands, Poland and Sweden. The other respondents in Italy, Lithuania and Slovakia were not aware of any such initiatives.

One initiative that is expected to be particularly relevant for EDIHs is the ongoing establishment of AI Factories under the umbrella of the EuroHPC JU initiative.[16] These AI Factories, that were not established yet at the time of interviews, are developing cutting-edge generative AI models by operating AI-dedicated supercomputers. Nearly all respondents are aware of the broader EuroHPC JU (15 out of 16), and about 40% also knew about the AI Factories initiative.[17] However, only a third of respondents consider that they have clients that might need such infrastructures, while 37% consider them irrelevant to their SMEs customers that have small datasets and data processing needs and are at lower levels of digitalisation. Some also do not consider it critical to their own activities, referring to the existence of other EDIHs in their country focusing more on model or product development compared to themselves. Nevertheless, more than half of them indicate that, if need arises, they can

[15] The question was introduced after the pilot group and therefore asked to 9 hubs only.

[16] The European High-Performance Computing Joint Undertaking (EuroHPC JU) was launched in November 2018 and consists of pooling HPC capacities are the European level. AI factories are recently launched sub-component of this undertaking.

[17] It is worth noting that the question statement was long and led respondents to confuse the Euro HPC initiative with the specific AI factories subcomponent.

connect the customer with an HPC facility (and by extension with an AI Factory once established). One respondent indicated that they applied to the call for AI Factories that was just published at the time of the interview.

3.4 Increasing awareness of AI opportunities and training the workforce

The fourth and last capability that we assess in to increase awareness and understanding of AI, as well as training the workforce on AI skills, while considering the environmental and social impacts of AI and improving customers' understanding of AI-related regulations and compliance during implementation.

In Figure 2, we noted that 81% of respondents provide support in AI-specific talent development, which sometimes covers the topics of environmental and social impacts of AI. However, a smaller proportion of respondents indicated supporting customers in regulation and ethics guidance (62%) and supporting other EDIHs build AI capacities (e.g. through "train-the-trainer" sessions; 44%), making these two functions the weakest ones in the EDIH Network.

3.4.1 Sustainability Assessment

Respondents were generally little knowledgeable about the social and environmental implications of AI.[18] Those with some knowledge mentioned discussing these topics at the margin during their training and awareness raising activities. During AI implementation, only 20% of respondents reported to support their customers in assessing either the environmental or the social impacts of AI adoption.[19] The support offered by the two EDIHs which replied positively is very early-stage, focusing on measuring patient engagement in the health sector in one instance and the energy cost and waste reduction to prioritise the most efficient solutions with regards to the environment in the other. They use basic tools or methodologies to facilitate this assessment.

3.4.2 Regulatory expertise and compliance capacity

In terms of legal and regulatory expertise to support AI adoption among their customers, all but one respondent report having some expertise in the matter. As indicated on Figure 10, the legal expertise is most often available from one of the EDIH partners (75% of respondents), which can be

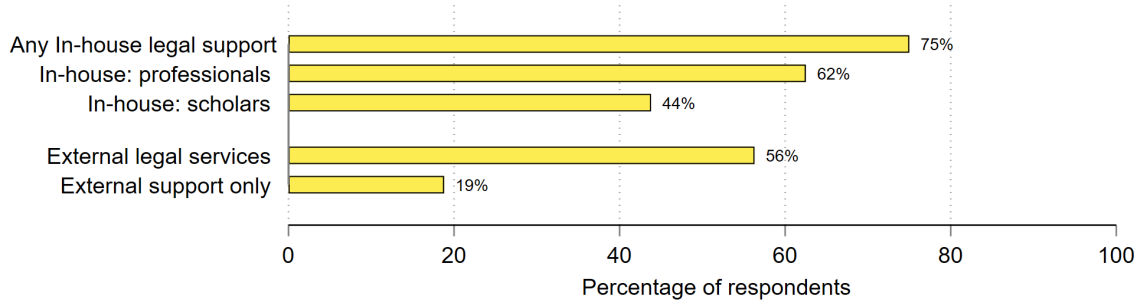
- A professional service or department dealing with practical cases, for instance a technology transfer office from the university or an incubator, or a single lawyer (62% of respondents).
- And/or legal scholars from an academic partner (44% of respondents).

56% of respondents also or alternatively recur to external legal services (consulting), among which 19% rely exclusively on this option.

[18] The social and environmental implications of AI are multifaceted and far-reaching. On the social front, AI raises significant concerns, including job displacement, perpetuation of biases and discrimination, and erosion of privacy. Meanwhile, the environmental footprint of AI is also a growing concern, with issues such as energy consumption, electronic waste, and resource extraction contributing to a complex and interconnected set of challenges that require careful consideration and mitigation.

[19] Please note the question 11 was asked to only 9 hubs. 7 of them replied they do not assess the environmental and social impacts of AI adoption.

Figure 10. Percentage of respondent with legal and regulatory expertise, in-house or through consulting, to support AI adoption



Note: This figure displays the different modalities of legal support that respondents offer to their customers for AI adoption. It corresponds to the open-ended question 9 in Annex Table 3. The two main non-exclusive modalities mentioned by respondents are in-house legal support and external consulting services. Among in-house services available, two non-exclusive forms are reported: a professional service dedicated to legal matters, and a department of research scholars in a university/research institute.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

It is worth noting that if nearly all respondents have access to some legal expertise, only 44% of them are offering this expertise as a service to their customers (Figure 2).

Focusing more specifically on EDIHs' knowledge of the AI Act,[20] about a third of respondents admit having a rather basic level of understanding of the legislation, along with another third with an intermediate level, and altogether do not provide any guidance to their customers in developing AI-enabled products and services on how to make them compliant with the provisions the AI Act, or in occasional instances would provide some guidance but only on clients' request. The remaining third of respondents is more advanced and generally provides guidance to their clients to comply with the legislation, most often through information sessions (webinars, events), but they have not developed and implemented a formal process or checklist to systematise this clients' guidance. It is also worth noting that the AI Act was adopted only a few months prior to the interviews and had not applied yet. Some EDIHs mentioned that, at the time of interviews, they were still waiting for clearer compliance procedures and rules from governments and at the EU level.[21]

In the meantime, the European Commission has launched initiatives such as the Code of Practice on General-Purpose AI,[22] guidelines and the launch of the AI Act Service Desk[23] that deliver clarity regarding the applicable rules of the AI Act and support for their application. The Commission also developed an AI innovation training package for EDIHs that helps them have a better understanding of the AI Act and the innovation ecosystem.

[20] The AI Act was adopted on June 13, 2024, a few months before the interviews, entered into force 20 days later and will be applied two years later. See Regulation (EU) 2024/1689 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 13 June 2024 laying down harmonised rules on artificial intelligence (Artificial Intelligence Act).

[21] Question 10 in Annex Table 3.

[22] https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/contents-code-gpai

[23] https://ai-act-service-desk.ec.europa.eu

4 Conclusion and policy recommendations

In this report, we conducted 16 interviews with EDIHs, complemented with EDIH-reported data on their activities, to understand the capabilities that exist in the EDIH Network with regards to supporting AI uptake across Europe. While most AI-related functions are available, the EDIH Network shows a relative weakness in AI regulation and ethics' guidance and capacity building for other EDIHs.

EDIHs identify and address a number of challenges that their customers face in adopting AI. The main barriers that EDIH customers face are resource constraints and the lack of AI literacy. EDIHs actively support them with awareness raising sessions and trainings and mentoring to improve their data collection processes or brokering to outside providers, while a few EDIHs also developed a dedicated AI maturity assessment tool to assess customers' readiness for AI implementation and establish a suitable roadmap.

The EDIHs interviewed displayed a greater heterogeneity in helping customers implement AI solutions. Established branches and applications are more frequently offered among respondents, such as machine learning and data analytics, than frontier ones, such as expert systems and articulated robotics, for instance. They support implementation mainly in the manufacturing and processing, health care and energy sectors, and rely rarely on their own or private datasets for AI model training, while not perceiving themselves are playing a leading role as trusted data intermediaries.

EDIHs leverage the AI ecosystem to serve their customers' needs, although to different extents depending on the type of ecosystem actor. They are well connected to digital providers, AI experts and testing and experimentation facilities, but less well connected to AI regulatory sandbox and AI framework providers, or AI standardisation bodies. They support customers in access to finance, although the funding is generally not specific to AI. EDIHs are sometimes aware of other AI initiatives in their local ecosystem but they were little knowledgeable of the AI Factories component of the EuroHPC JU at the time of the interviews. However, only a third of them could perceived the relevance of AI Factories for their customers.

Finally, EDIHs actively work towards increasing awareness of AI opportunities and training the workforce in AI knowledge and tools, with some caveats when it comes to assessing the environmental and social impacts of AI or providing regulation and ethics' guidance to customers. They show a genuine interest in developing further this competency soon and many indicated a need to implement systematic procedures to check compliance with the AI Act during implementation.

Looking forward, EDIHs are generally expecting AI to play an increasing role in their service delivery. 56% of them indicated intentions to increase their regulation and ethics' guidance offer through training their lawyers and providing services of legal counselling on how to be compliant with the AI Act. 44% also intend to offer more workshops and training on AI, and 31% are considering acquiring an AI assessment tool to better guide their clients (see Annex Figure 11).

AI is deemed to play an increasing role in EDIHs' activities, as they were already expecting at the time of interviews in view of the evolution of the technology and demands from their customers, but also with the priority set by the Commission. Indeed, the second generation of the EDIH Network will have

a reinforced focus on AI,[24] and serving as ambassadors of European AI solutions' providers and privileged access point to the AI innovation ecosystem.[25] In that sense, some actions beyond those already planned and undertaken, as mentioned in the previous section, can be suggested to support EDIHs in their mission to increase AI uptake in Europe:

- Encourage the EDIH Network to continue sharing use cases, as showcasing can build SME's confidence in the benefit of AI and drive engagement.
- Use the EDIH platform to provide more AI-dedicated information and training sessions to EDIHs on relevant initiatives and how to leverage them effectively.
- Establish a centralised helpdesk to strengthen legal expertise within the EDIH Network and help ensure compliance with regulations such as the AI Act.
- Encourage EDIHs to federate SMEs, possibly taking a sector-based approach, to build up a critical mass of data and computational needs before turning to an AI Factory. This would enable EDIHs to better understand the relevance of AI Factories / Gigafactories for their customers, and they may be more willing to take on the role of trusted data intermediaries.
- Finally, create a centralised AI resources directory for the Network considering the limited use of data beyond public and client ones, mapping in particular data available for AI model training, along with tools, frameworks, and standards, so EDIHs can access them more efficiently.

[24] EU Funding & Tenders Portal | EU Funding & Tenders Portal

[25] Apply AI Strategy, European Commission, 2025.

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List of abbreviations and definitions

Abbreviations	Definitions
AI	Artificial Intelligence
DG CNECT	Directorate-General for Communications Networks, Content and Technology of the European Commission
DMAT	Digital Maturity Assessment tool
EDIH	European Digital Innovation Hubs
EuroHPC JU	European High-Performance Computing Joint Undertaking
HPC	High-Performance Computing

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Table 3. List of questions asked during the interview

Question 1. Would you like to describe briefly a few use cases that best illustrate your customer support in AI?
Question 2. What role does AI play in your current service delivery, and how do you envision it evolving?
Question 3. In which main sectors have you delivered AI services?
Question 4. Could you please elaborate on the branches of AI technologies that you have used in the services reported in the system? (e.g., machine learning, natural language processing, computer vision)
Question 5. What AI applications and related technologies do you currently use to support AI adoption by your clients? (e.g. Facial recognition, predictive analytics)
Question 6. What are the primary sources of data used in AI applications with your clients? (e.g., client-provided data, EDIH-collected data, public datasets, private datasets, etc.)
Question 7. Trusted data intermediaries are expected to provide a trusted and secure environment in which companies or individuals can share data for testing and developing of AI innovations. What is the level of your EDIH capability to collect industrial data from companies, anonymise it and then make it available to other companies for AI model testing?
Question 8. Can you name and describe which members of your EDIH you can rely on to address an AI-related request? Is any of these partners led by a woman?
Question 9. What legal and regulatory expertise do you have in-house or through consulting to support AI adoption, and how do you stay updated on relevant regulations? (e.g., advice on AI Act, data protection, intellectual property, contracts)
Question 10. How do they assess your knowledge of the AI Act? Do you actively guide your clients developing AI-enabled products and services on how to make them compliant with the provisions of the AI Act?
Question 11. Do you offer support to your customers in assessing the potential environmental and social impacts of AI adoption, and if so, what tools or methodologies do you use to facilitate this assessment?
Question 12. What are the most common barriers your clients face when adopting AI, and how do you address them?
Question 13. Do you have an AI maturity assessment tool to identify the AI readiness of your customer and opportunities for growth? If not, have you considered developing or acquiring one?
Question 14. Do you know in your ecosystem who to address for: • Companies that could take over the client in their digital journey • AI experts to rely on • AI frameworks • A regulatory sandbox for AI • AI testing & exp. facility • AI standardisation Please give some example(s) of organisations for each category.
Question 15. Are you aware of any other initiatives around AI in your ecosystem? If yes, please describe them briefly and explain how they differ from and interact with the work of your EDIH.

Question 16. Capitalising on the supercomputing capacity of the EuroHPC Joint Undertaking, AI Factories will develop cutting-edge generative AI models by operating AI-dedicated supercomputers.

- Are you familiar with AI Factories?
- Would you have clients needing access to such infrastructure to develop and test fast machine learning and training of large General Purpose AI (GPAI) models?
- Could your EDIH already provide such services?

Question 17. What motivates your interest in delivering AI services, and what benefits do you hope to achieve for your clients?

Question 18. How does your EDIH support clients in the following AI functions:

- AI adoption road mapping,
- solution deployment support,
- support to find investment for AI,
- innovation ecosystem & networking,
- test before invest & solution screening,
- talent development,
- regulation and ethics guidance, and
- capacity building for EDIHs?

How do your services align with your clients' needs in each of these areas?

Question 19. Which of the previous functions do you aim to develop or improve in the near future, and why are they important to your clients?

Question 20. What specific step do you plan to take to strengthen your AI capabilities and support your clients' AI adoption?

Question 21. Are you interested in becoming an AI EDIH and supporting others EDIHs on AI-related tasks? If so, what specific contribution do you envision making to the network?

Note: Questions 1, 3, 11 and 15 were introduced later in the data collection process so only 9 hubs answered them.

Source: JRC elaboration.

Table 4. List of questions in the pre-interview survey

3. In which main sectors have you delivered AI services?

☐ Aeronautics	☐ Maritime
☐ Agricultural biotechnology and food biotechnology	☐ Metal working and industrial production
☐ Automotive	☐ Mining and extraction
☐ Community-Led Local Development	☐ NMP Non-Metallic Materials & basic processes
☐ Construction & Assembly	☐ Nuclear
☐ Consumer products	☐ Paper and wood
☐ Cultural and creative economy	☐ Personal services
☐ Defence	☐ Polymers and plastics
☐ Education	☐ Public administration
☐ Electricity	☐ Real estate
☐ Energy	☐ Retail, wholesale or distribution
☐ Energy, fuels and petroleum engineering	☐ Security
☐ Environment	☐ Space
☐ Financial	☐ Telecommunications
☐ Fishery	☐ Textiles
☐ Food and beverages	☐ Tobacco
☐ Health care	☐ Transport & Mobility
☐ Leather	☐ Transport sector
☐ Life sciences	☐ Travel and tourism
☐ Manufacturing and processing	

4. Could you please elaborate on the branches of AI technologies that you have used in the services reported in the system?

☐ Machine learning (ML), including generative AI	☐ Computer vision
☐ Expert systems	☐ Knowledge representation
☐ Robotics	☐ Fuzzy logic
☐ Natural language processing (NLP)	☐ Human-Computer Interaction (HCI)

5. What AI applications and related technologies do you currently use to support AI adoption by your clients?

☐ Image recognition and classification	☐ Predictive analytics
☐ Image segmentation	☐ Recommendation systems
☐ Content based image retrieval	☐ Data analytics
☐ Object detection and/or tracking	☐ Automated stack trading
☐ Facial recognition	☐ Autonomous vehicles
☐ Text generation	☐ Articulated robotics
☐ Image generation	☐ Collaborative robotics
☐ Speech recognition	☐ Humanoid robotics
☐ Audio generation	☐ Autonomous robotics
☐ Video generation	☐ Fraud detection
☐ Large language models (LLMs)	☐ Predictive policing
☐ Chat bots and virtual assistants	☐ Edge AI
☐ Text classification	☐ Cloud AI
☐ Sentiment analysis	☐ Data centres
☐ Data curation	

14. In your ecosystem, do you know an organization that provides the following AI-related services? If yes, please provide specific examples.

Service	Answer	Example(s)
Digital transformation partners	☐ Yes ☐ No	
AI expertise	☐ Yes ☐ No	
AI framework providers	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Regulatory sandbox providers	☐ Yes ☐ No	
AI testing and experimentation facilities	☐ Yes ☐ No	
AI standardization bodies	☐ Yes ☐ No	

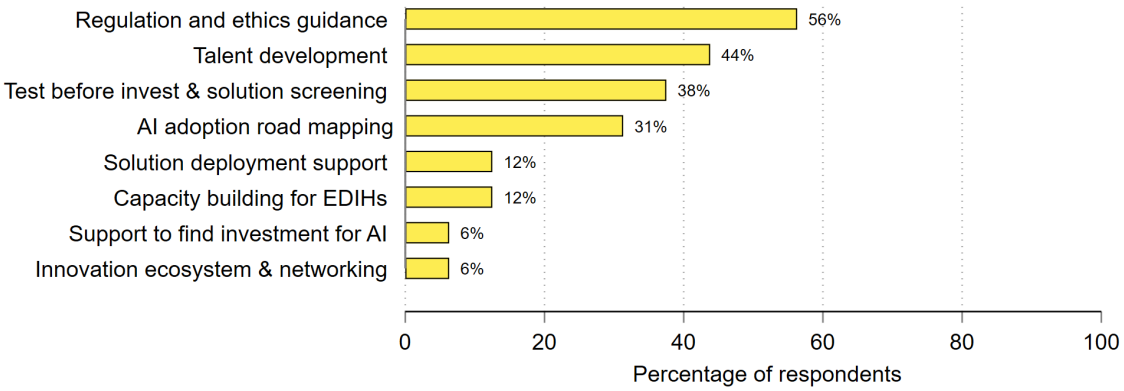
18. Does your EDIH provide support to clients in the following AI functions? If yes, please provide specific examples.

Function	Answer	Example(s)	Needed by clients?
AI adoption road mapping	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No
Solution deployment support	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No
Support to find investment for AI	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No
Innovation ecosystem & networking	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No
Test before invest & solution screening	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No
Talent development	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No
Regulation and ethics guidance	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No
Capacity building for EDIHs	☐ Yes ☐ No		☐ Yes ☐ No

Note: This survey was introduced later in the data collection process and only 9 hubs received it prior to the interview. The other interviewees received it after the interview.

Source: JRC elaboration.

Figure 11. Percentage of respondents aiming at developing or improving different AI-related functions in the near future



Note: This figure displays the percentage of EDIHs which mentioned intentions to develop further each of the AI-related function. The near future refers to the upcoming three years. It corresponds to question 19 of Annex Table 3.

Source: JRC calculations based on interviews.

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